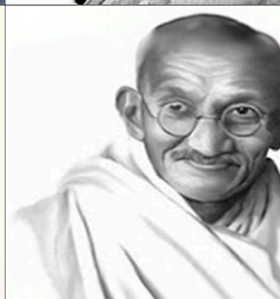


General Knowledge

Modern History

STUDY NOTES

The Great Revolt of 1857



THE REVOLT OF 1857



- The Revolt of 1857, also known as India's First War of Independence, was a widespread but unsuccessful uprising against British rule in India.
- It marked a significant turning point in Indian history, sowing the seeds for future movements against colonialism.

Causes of the Revolt

Economic Causes:

- **Destruction of Traditional Economy:**
 - British policies led to the collapse of traditional industries.
- **Heavy Duties on Indian Goods:**
 - Indian goods faced heavy taxation in British markets.
 - Example: Textiles faced tariffs exceeding 80%.
- **Exploitative Revenue Policies:**
 - High taxes impoverished peasants.
 - Peasants fell into debt; suffered severe poverty.
- **Commercialization of Agriculture:**
 - Shift from food crops (wheat, rice) to cash crops (sugarcane, cotton, indigo).

- Led to loss of self-sufficiency and food security.
- **Deindustrialization:**
 - Loss of Artisan Livelihoods: Artisans and craftsmen lost patronage due to annexation.
- **Unfavorable Trade Policies:**
 - British goods imported into India duty-free.
 - Indian exports faced heavy tariffs in Britain.
 - Modern Transport Favored British Goods:
 - Railways and ships used to transport British products, undermining local industries.

Administrative Causes

- **Corruption:**
 - Rampant corruption in police and judiciary eroded trust.
- **Discrimination:**
 - Indians excluded from higher administrative posts.
 - Educated Indians faced job discrimination.
- **Loss of Patronage:**
 - Artists, musicians, and cultural figures lost support from erstwhile Indian rulers.

Socio-Religious Causes

- **Racial Discrimination:**
 - Indians faced segregation and disrespect.
- **Cultural Interference:**
 - Religious Disabilities Act, 1850:
 - Allowed converts to inherit ancestral property.
 - Seen as an attack on traditional religious practices.
- **Social Reforms Imposed:**
 - Abolition of Sati (1829).
 - Widow Remarriage Act (1856).
 - Promotion of female education.

- These were perceived as intrusive and disrespectful to Indian traditions.

Political Causes

- **Annexation Policies:**

- Subsidiary Alliance.
- Doctrine of Lapse.
- Direct Annexation.
- Undermined the power and prestige of Indian rulers.

- **Loss of Sovereignty:**

- Kings and princes felt dishonored and marginalized.
- Led to widespread dissatisfaction among the ruling classes.

Military Causes

- **Discontent Among Sepoys:**

- General Service Enlistment Act, 1856:
- Required sepoys to serve overseas, violating caste norms.

- **Erosion of Privileges:**

- Restrictions on religious practices and symbols.

- **Discrimination:**

- Indian soldiers faced inferior treatment and pay compared to British troops.

Immediate Cause

- **Introduction of Enfield Rifles:**

- Cartridges rumored to be greased with cow and pig fat.
- Offensive to Hindus (cow) and Muslims (pig).

- **Mangal Pandey:**

- On April 8, 1857, he attacked British officers at Barrackpore.

- **Meerut Incident:**

- On May 9, 1857, 85 sepoys refused the cartridges; sentenced to imprisonment.
- Sparked open rebellion on May 10, 1857.

Course of the Revolt

- **Outbreak in Meerut**

- Sepoys rebelled, killing British officers.
- Marched to Delhi, joined by other soldiers and civilians.

- **Proclamation of Bahadur Shah Zafar**

- Mughal Emperor declared the leader of the revolt.
- Symbolized unity and legitimacy.

- **Spread of the Revolt**

- Regions Involved:
- From Punjab in the north to Narmada in the south.
- Bihar in the east to Rajputana in the west.
- Civilian Participation:
- Peasants, artisans, shopkeepers, and zamindars joined.
- Attacked symbols of British authority: law courts, revenue offices.

- **Major Centers and Leaders**

Place	Leaders
Delhi	Bahadur Shah Zafar, General Bakht Khan
Kanpur	Nana Sahib, Tatya Tope
Lucknow	Begum Hazrat Mahal, Birjis Qadir
Jhansi	Rani Lakshmi Bai
Bareilly	Khan Bahadur Khan
Faizabad	Maulvi Ahmadullah

Arrah (Bihar)	Kunwar Singh, Amar Singh
Baghpat	Shah Mal

British Response and Suppression

- Recapture of Delhi: September 20, 1857.
- Bahadur Shah Zafar exiled to Rangoon; his sons executed.
- **Suppression in Other Regions:**
 - Kanpur: Nana Sahib defeated; Tatya Tope captured and executed in 1859.
 - Jhansi: Rani Lakshmi Bai killed in battle.
 - Lucknow: Recaptured after heavy fighting.

Casualties:

- Approximately 150,000 Indians were killed, including civilians.

Reasons for the Failure of the Revolt

1. Limited Geographical Spread

- Revolt confined mainly to North India.
- South, East, and most of Western India remained largely unaffected.

2. Lack of Unity and Coordination

- No centralized leadership or unified command.
- Diverse goals among rebels; lacked a coherent strategy.

3. Superior British Resources

- Better arms and ammunition.
- Effective use of the telegraph for communication.

4. Loyal Indian States

- Some princely states and rulers did not join the revolt.
- Examples: Scindia of Gwalior, Holkar of Indore, Nizam of Hyderabad, Sikh rulers

5. Class and Social Divisions

- Many landlords and zamindars supported the British.
- Educated Indians viewed the revolt as backward-looking.

6. Lack of Clear Vision

- Rebels lacked a unified ideology or plan for post-British governance.
- Primarily a reaction against specific grievances rather than a nationalist movement.

Consequences of the Revolt

1. End of East India Company Rule

- Government of India Act, 1858:
- British Crown assumed direct control.
- Position of Viceroy established (replacing Governor-General).
- Secretary of State for India appointed in the British Cabinet.

2. Changes in Policies

- Queen's Proclamation, 1858:
- Promised non-interference in religious matters.
- Equal opportunities in government appointments (though not fully implemented).
- Recognition of princes' rights and cessation of annexations.

3. Reorganization of the Army

- Peel Commission Recommendations:
- Increased ratio of British to Indian soldiers.
- Segregation of units based on caste, community, and region to prevent unity.
- Indians excluded from artillery.
- Strict control to prevent future rebellions.

4. Impact on Indian Society

- **Rise of Nationalism:**
 - Exposed the exploitative nature of British rule.
 - Inspired future generations to fight for independence.
- **Policy of Divide and Rule:**
 - British exploited religious, caste, and regional differences to maintain control.
 - Significance of the Revolt
 - First Major Challenge to British rule.
- **Symbol of Resistance:**
 - Inspired later freedom movements.
- **Highlighted Exploitation:**
 - Brought attention to economic and social injustices.

Key Personalities

Rebel Leaders

Name	Role
Bahadur Shah Zafar	Mughal Emperor; symbolic leader
Nana Sahib	Leader at Kanpur
Rani Lakshmi Bai	Queen of Jhansi; fought valiantly
Tatya Tope	General of Nana Sahib
Kunwar Singh	Leader in Bihar
Begum Hazrat Mahal	Leader in Lucknow
Maulvi Ahmadullah	Leader in Faizabad

Khan Bahadur Khan	Leader in Bareilly
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British Officials

Name	Position
Sir Colin Campbell	Commander-in-Chief, suppressed revolt
Sir Hugh Rose	Defeated Rani Lakshmi Bai
Henry Havelock	Key role in recapturing Kanpur
Colonel James Neill	Suppressed revolt in Banaras

Differing Perspectives on the Revolt

British View:

Labelled it a "Sepoy Mutiny" or military rebellion.
Saw it as a localized uprising without mass support.
scope.

Indian Nationalist View:

V.D. Savarkar termed it the "First War of Independence."
Seen as a collective effort to overthrow British rule.

Historians View:

R.C. Majumdar: Not a national war; limited in scope.
Karl Marx: Recognized it as a national revolt against imperialism.

Conclusion

- The Revolt of 1857 was a significant event that exposed the vulnerabilities of British colonial rule and the deep-seated discontent among various sections of Indian society.
- While it failed to end British dominance, it set the stage for future struggles for independence and fostered a sense of national consciousness among Indians.